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ARTICLE

The Purge Begins: Biblical Pastors Need Not Apply





BY PNW STAFF JULY 06, 2026

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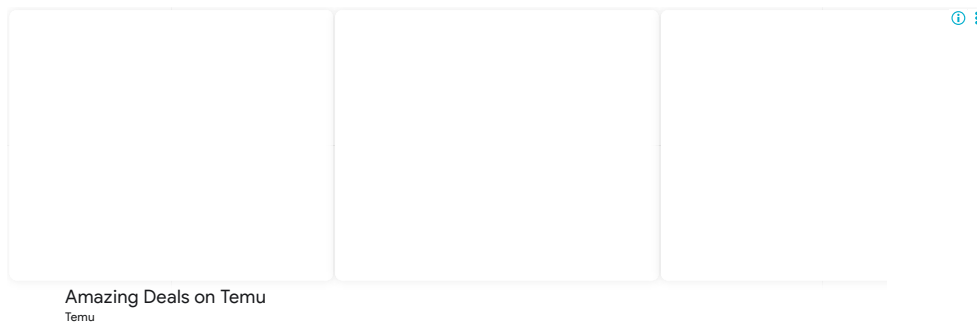
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The Presbyterian Church has spent decades debating sexuality, marriage, and biblical authority. But its latest decision may represent something far more consequential than another policy change. It creates a system that allows churches to screen pastors based on their views of LGBTQ theology before they are ever seriously considered for ministry.

Supporters call it efficiency.

Critics see the beginning of a theological purge.

At the 227th General Assembly, commissioners approved GEN-06, directing the denomination's Church Leadership Connection to add an optional feature to its Ministry Discernment Profile—the official database churches use when searching for pastors.



The new feature allows congregations to indicate their openness to calling an LGBTQIA+ pastor and enables search committees to filter candidates according to several positions, including whether they identify as LGBTQIA+, whether they will perform same-sex marriages, and whether they support the ordination of LGBTQ elders, deacons, and ministers.

On paper, the proposal sounds reasonable. Churches can more easily find pastors who share their convictions, avoiding lengthy interviews that were never likely to result in a match.

But that assumes the denomination remains theologically balanced.

The Presbyterian Church (USA) has spent years steadily embracing progressive positions on sexuality. It has rewritten its constitution to include LGBTQIA+ protections, approved same-sex marriage, and opened ordination to openly LGBTQ ministers. This new filtering system doesn't create a new direction—it accelerates one already well underway.

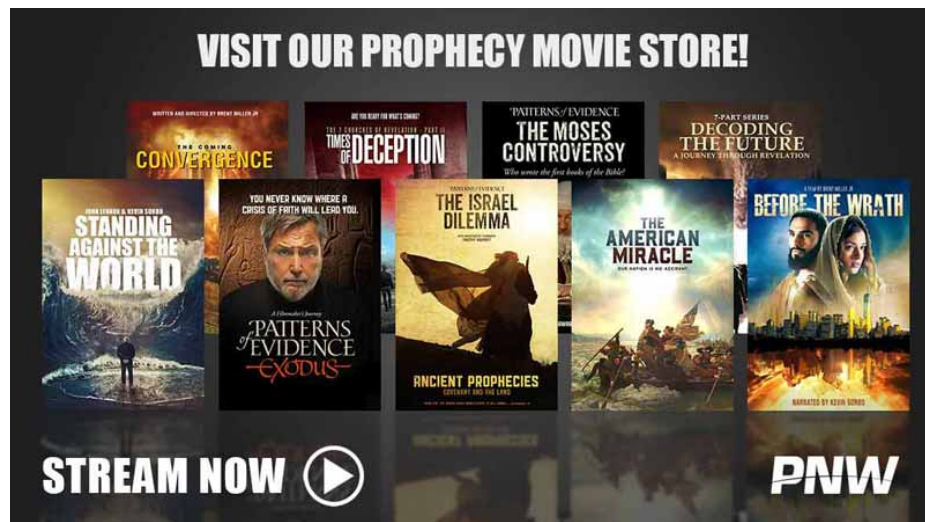


And that's why many conservatives aren't fooled by the language of "choice."

In today's institutional culture, formal requirements are often unnecessary. Hiring committees, search tools, and screening questions quietly accomplish what official policies never have to say out loud.

The question becomes remarkably simple:

Do you affirm our theology on sexuality?



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If the answer is yes, your application moves forward.

If the answer is no—even because you sincerely believe Scripture teaches otherwise—your profile may never receive another look.

That is why many view this less as a matching tool and more as a litmus test.

Supporters insist conservative churches remain free to call pastors who hold traditional biblical convictions. Technically, that remains true.

But denominations are ecosystems. Seminaries shape future pastors. Committees shape leadership. Search systems shape opportunity. Once a denomination overwhelmingly moves in one theological direction, these kinds of screening tools inevitably reinforce that movement.

The result is predictable. Progressive churches can quickly identify affirming pastors, while pastors holding historic Christian beliefs find themselves considered by fewer and fewer congregations. No formal expulsion is necessary. The filtering quietly accomplishes the same outcome.

The irony is difficult to miss.

For years, progressives have championed diversity and inclusion. Yet one of Christianity's oldest and most universally held doctrines—that marriage is between one man and one woman—is increasingly treated not as a legitimate theological conviction but as evidence that someone is unfit for ministry.

For nearly two thousand years, Christians across traditions held this understanding of marriage. Today, within parts of mainline Protestantism, that historic belief is becoming the position that must be defended.

Ultimately, this debate isn't merely about sexuality.

It is about authority.

Will the church allow Scripture to shape its beliefs, even when those beliefs collide with the culture? Or will cultural expectations become the lens through which Scripture is reinterpreted?

The Apostle Paul warned Timothy that a time would come when people would no longer endure sound doctrine but would instead seek teachers who told them what they wanted to hear. Those words were written not about the world, but about pressures arising within the church itself.

Every generation of believers faces moments when faithfulness carries a cost. Increasingly, that cost may simply be holding to what Christians have believed since the beginning.

Policies like this clarify the choice.

The question is no longer whether the Presbyterian Church is changing.

The question is whether pastors who continue to believe the Bible's teaching on marriage still have a place within it.

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